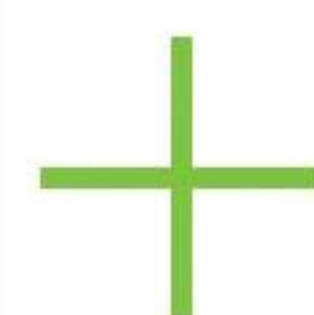




Key performers for Diamond Harbour FC in 2024-25 season (goals/assists):

Narohari Shrestha (forward)

CFL — 7/3

I-League 3 — 8/3

I-League 2 — 5/1

Jobby Justin (midfielder)

CFL — 10/5

I-League 3 — 2/5

I-League 2 — 4/4

Girik Khosla (midfielder/winger)

CFL — 5/4

I-League 3 — 2/1

I-League 2 — 5/4

Rabilal Mandi (defender/left back)

CFL — 1 assist

I-League 2 — 2/1

Winds of change: Head coach Kibu Vicuna has had a transformative impact on the team.

build a lasting impact in the hearts of our fans at home. And now, by winning championships, we are hopeful of garnering support from all parts of West Bengal," Akash says.

Sustaining the momentum will be the biggest challenge when it embarks on the more difficult job of excelling in the I-League. "This is our fourth season in football. In the past three seasons we have performed really well with a very high success rate. Now the competition gets really tough, as you have to play on different surfaces and in varying weather conditions against

opponents who are quite capable. The challenge will be bigger but we are preparing for that," says Vicuna while assessing his team's prospects. "It is important for us now to prepare a proper game model by getting the right balance in the side between the foreign and Indian players," he added.

Vicuna says the experience of helping Mohun Bagan to the I-League title will definitely count, but this is a new assignment offering new challenges. "We are a very exciting side and we will try to play the right version of football to get good results, much like the way we have done so far," he said.

Climbing the success ladder means a rising level of investment in terms of money and resources. In a

situation where the legacy clubs like East Bengal and Mohammedan Sporting are struggling to draw enough funds to create a competitive side according to the demands of the ISL, how does DHFC plan to stand up to this challenge?

"Most of our sponsors have been supporting us since the formation of the club. We are thankful to each and every one of them. Also, the club's success has brought in many more names who are ready to support us. We are currently focused on the current calendar year, but when the time comes, we are confident that our sponsors will support us in a bigger way once we are able to qualify for the Indian Super League," Akash is hopeful about DHFC's great future.